

EUGLENA WHO? – Mitsuru Izumo believes in eco-friendly capitalism. He hopes to use a tiny, single-celled creature to make it a reality.

NATASHA R. SILVA (TEXT),
ANDREW CURRY (PHOTO)

GREEN GOLD

Can something smaller than the thickness of a human hair be the answer to a problem as big as hunger? In Mitsuru Izumo's opinion, yes. The Founder and President of Euglena Co saw the horrible effects of malnutrition during a trip to Bangladesh in 1998. Izumo was just 18 at the time, a student focusing on international development at the University of Tokyo. He was touched by the poverty he saw in the South Asian country. "In Bangladesh there was food. People ate a lot of rice and carbohydrates. But they didn't have access to any food that was really nutritional," he says. "The problem there was not starvation, it was malnutrition."

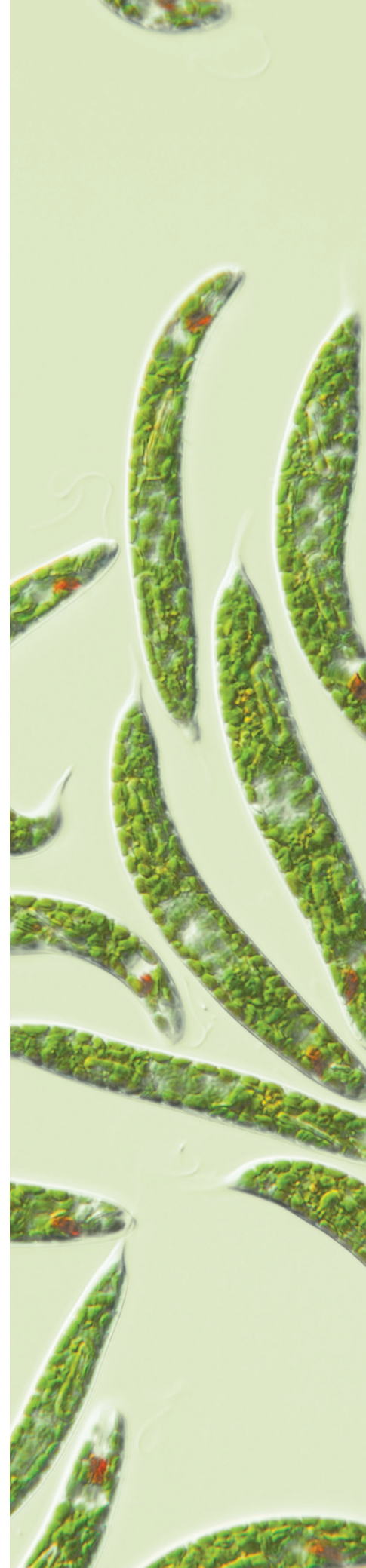
Two years later, when he was home in Japan again, Izumo was introduced to the health benefits of *euglena*: a type of tiny microorganism that contains a lot of potential. *Euglena* is an algae that has characteristics of both plants and animals. It can be found in fresh water and is a source of nutrients for many other microorganisms.

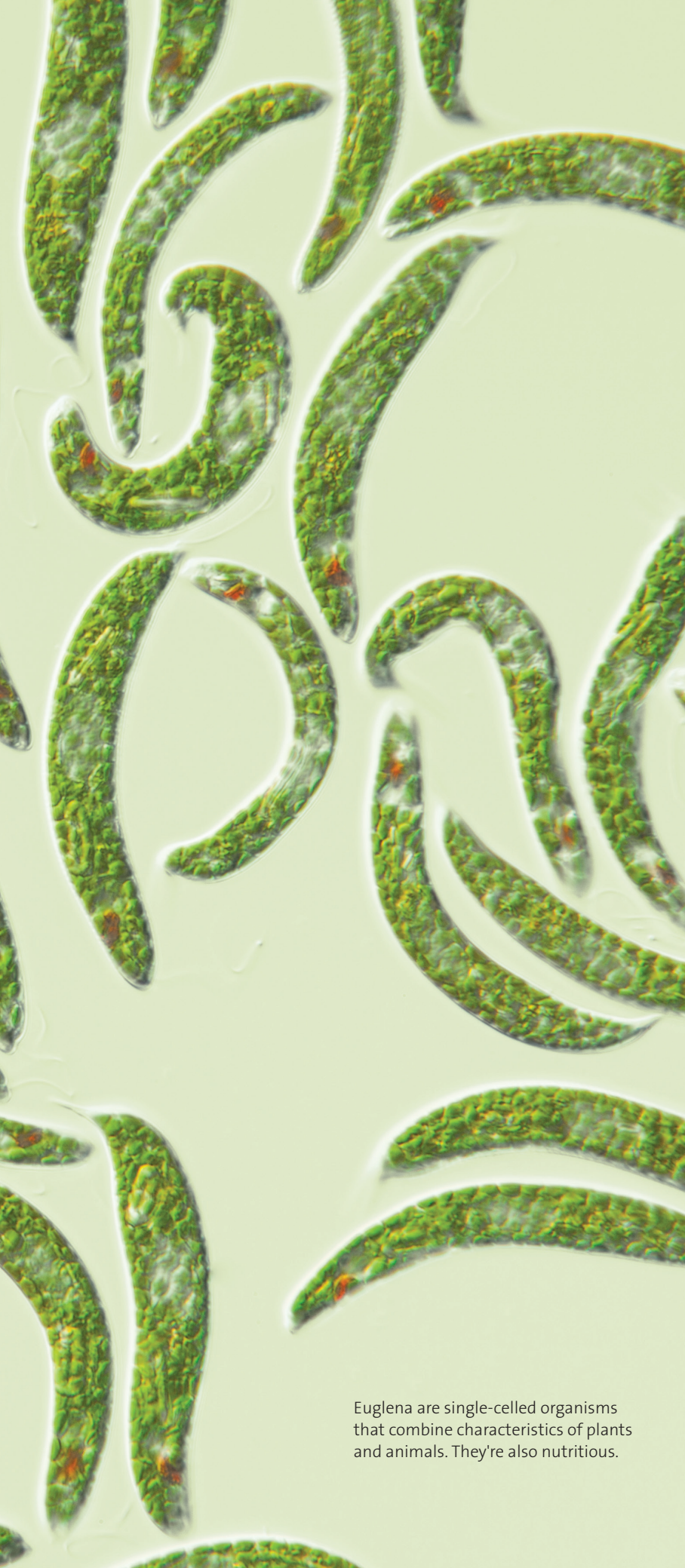
Realising its great nutritional and carbon capture capabilities, Izumo immediately saw his opportunity to help the mal-

nourished children he saw in Bangladesh and started his own business at the same time. "I joined a special research and development programme at my university to try and cultivate *euglena* massively," Izumo says. His main goal was to find a way to produce this kind of microalgae at an industrial scale and make it available – in the form of a powder that can be used as a supplement – for people who truly needed it.

It was not an easy path, though. It was only in 2005 that Izumo successfully developed a technology that allowed him to cultivate *euglena* cheaply enough to make the final product accessible. In August 2005, Euglena Co was born. Research continued, but it took a while for the founder of the company to get clients that believed in his project. "There's one thing I said from the start: 'This is a business. I want to make profit in Japan and Europe, but, I want to invest most of that profit in doing social business in developing countries,'" says Izumo.

In time, Euglena Co caught the eye of investors, going from a struggling business to a huge hit. In 2012, the company went





Euglena are single-celled organisms that combine characteristics of plants and animals. They're also nutritious.



public in a JPY 10 billion (USD 81 million) stock market launch and has been growing around 30 per cent each year since. However, the success of the company did not distract its founder from his initial goals. The ideology that was born during that trip in 1998 is still with Izumo and affects every decision he makes.

Right now, he continues making a profit, but invests a lot of it in charity programmes that offer school lunches – *euglena* cookies included, of course – for kids in Bangladesh. “In these times of greedy capitalism, almost all my shareholders push me to make more profit,” says Izumo.

That fact does not seem to make Izumo nervous, though. For him, there is no need to draw a line between business and his beliefs. “I have a special technology to cultivate *euglena* and no one else has it,” he says. “So I can decide what the priorities are. If young social entrepreneurs develop proper and innovative technology, we can make eco-friendly, social and public interest capitalism really happen.” ♦